



Marital status transition probabilities in Indonesia: based on the 2007 and 2014 Indonesia Family Life Survey (IFLS)

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Abstract

This paper contributes to the first calculation of marital status transition probabilities in Indonesia using the Indonesian Family Life Survey (IFLS), a longitudinal survey conducted since 1993. The sample consists of individuals aged 15 and over in Wave-4 (2007) who were re-interviewed in Wave-5 (2014). The study calculates transition probabilities for five marital status changes: from never married to married, married to widowed, married to divorced, widowed to remarried, and divorced to remarried. The analysis is conducted based on age, education, geography (urban-rural residence and islands), and key social markers (ethnicity and religion), with sex as a control variable across all dimensions. Among others, it concludes that the transition probability from never married to married is consistently higher among females than males, regardless of education, geography, and social markers, with an exception among the group—aged 35 years old and over. Once married, most individuals remain married, though some experience a shift in marital status, transitioning to either widowed or divorced. The transition probability from married to widowed increases with age, making it significantly more common than divorce among individuals aged 50 years and over. This pattern—that transition probability is higher to widowed than to divorced- is consistent across both sexes, all education levels, geography, and social markers. After becoming widowed or divorced, some individuals remarry. However, the likelihood of remarrying differs importantly depending on the previous marital status, with the transition probability from divorced to remarried consistently higher than from widowed to remarried, irrespective of sex, age, education, geography, and social markers.

Keywords Marital status transition · Indonesia · Married · Remarried · Divorced · Widowed

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1 Introduction

As a significant life transition, marriage marks an important moment in individuals' lives, shaping their identities, roles, relationships, and life trajectories across different life stages. It is a fundamental institution in society, characterized by profound personal and social implications. Marriage remains prevalent in many parts of Southeast and South Asia (Dommaraju & Wong, 2023; Nobles & Buitenheim, 2008). However, delayed marriage has become increasingly common (Abdullah et al., 2021; Dommaraju & Wong, 2023; Jones, 2007). Meanwhile, divorce rates have been rising in several Asian countries, including Malaysia (Jones, 2021), China (Chen et al., 2021; Yeung & Jones, 2023), the Philippines, Indonesia, and Taiwan (Yeung & Jones, 2023). As this topic is further explored, it is important to understand marital status and the probability of transitioning from one marital status to another.

Marital status is a dynamic aspect of the life course. From the joyful union of marriage marking the transition into adulthood to the profound challenges of navigating divorce or coping with the loss of a spouse through widowhood, each stage brings its own set of experiences, challenges, and adjustments (An et al., 2023). These transitions can profoundly affect individuals, influencing their emotional well-being, social connections, and even health outcomes (Manzoli et al., 2007; Sbarra et al., 2011). Marital transitions, such as marriage, divorce, and widowhood, not only impact individuals but also reshape the structure and dynamics of their families. As these changes unfold, they intersect with broader shifts in the concept of family, which has evolved over time.

The concept of the family as an institution has undergone continual evolution. It is worth noting that a disparity between the notions of family and household can often exist. In contemporary society, it is not uncommon for members of a single family to reside in separate households. This dynamic reflects the diverse ways families are structured today (Smock & Schwartz, 2020).

Moreover, the pervasive use of digital technology has revolutionized familial connectivity, transcending geographical distances. This paradigm shift has given rise to what Ananta (2021) referred to as a “digitally super-extended family”. Through various digital platforms and communication tools, family members across different generations and geographical locations can maintain robust connections and meaningful relationships, fostering a sense of unity despite geographical separation.

Previous studies have explored the sociological dimensions of marital status transitions, drawing upon theoretical frameworks such as role theory, social exchange theory, and symbolic interactionism theory (Fitzpatrick, 2023; Kreager et al., 2013; Nakonezny & Denton, 2008). These studies examined various factors influencing marital transitions, including cultural norms, socioeconomic status, and individual experiences. Additionally, they explored the challenges and adjustments couples face during these transitions, such as renegotiating roles, managing conflict, and adapting to new familial dynamics.

However, there has been a lack of quantitative research examining the probability of transitioning from one marital status to another. This paper addresses that gap using an Indonesian longitudinal data set, specifically the Wave-4 and Wave-5 of the Indonesian Family Life Survey. Understanding marital transitions is an essential part

of the broader study of family dynamics, which has been explored in various ways within the field of family demography.

In this field, Smock and Schwartz (2020) identified two primary types of studies. The first involves meticulous observation and measurement of families at specific points in time or across periods to track trends. This encompasses documenting various aspects such as family composition, transitions like marriage, divorce, and childbirth, as well as socioeconomic factors like income and education levels. This documentation is crucial for understanding shifts in the familial landscape. The second type of study delves into the social, cultural, and economic factors associated with family structures and transitions, exploring their causes and consequences.

This paper falls under the first type of study, contributing to the existing literature by estimating the transition probabilities between different marital statuses: from being never married to married, from married to divorced or widowed, from widowed to remarried, and from divorced to remarried. Each transition involves its own set of challenges, adjustments, and legal implications. By analyzing these transitions, researchers can gain deeper insights into societal changes regarding attitudes toward marital status dynamics.

With Indonesia undergoing a demographic transition in a rapidly developing economy, alongside significant improvements in education and gender equality, the country offers an ideal setting to understand marital status transitions. By utilising Wave-4 (2007) and Wave-5 (2014) of the *Indonesia Family Life Survey*, which includes detailed marriage histories, this paper calculates the probabilities of various marital status transitions.

The next section reviews previous studies on changes in marital status, including the limited research exploring transitions from married to widowed or divorced, and from widowed or divorced to remarried. This is followed by a discussion of the data and methods used to calculate transition probabilities. The results section then presents the estimated probabilities, disaggregated by sex, age, education, geography (urban-rural residence and islands), and social markers (ethnicity and religion). The paper concludes with a discussion of the findings and their implications.

2 Marriage formation and dissolution in Indonesia

Indonesia, a vast archipelagic country with a population of 270 million in 2020, is home to more than 700 ethnic groups and six official religions, with many sects within each religion (Ananta et al., 2015). This diversity contributes to a highly heterogeneous and, at times, competing cultural landscape, particularly in terms of norms surrounding family institutions. Consequently, caution is needed when discussing “Indonesia” as a singular entity (Utomo et al., 2022). The discussion in this paper should be interpreted within this context.

In Southeast Asia, including Indonesia, significant shifts in marital trends have emerged (Heaton et al., 2001; Jones, 2023; Nobles & Bütünheim, 2008; Situmorang, 2007; Yeung & Jones, 2023). Traditionally, marriages occurred at younger ages, but there has been a notable delay in both men and women marrying (Situmorang, 2007, 2015), with some individuals opting to remain single indefinitely. Particularly strik-

ing is the growing number of women aged 30–34 who have never married, reflecting evolving societal norms and individual choices. Moreover, divorce rates have risen, contributing to an increased pool of individuals seeking remarriage (Dommaraju, 2023). This shift highlights evolving attitudes toward marriage and relationships, reflecting the growing autonomy individuals have in shaping their personal lives and making independent decisions.

Table 1 shows the predominant rising trend of marriage as the primary form of union in Indonesia over 30 years (1987–2017) among women aged 15–49, possibly attributed to a shift toward an older age composition, despite a minor decrease of 1.5% points from 2012 to 2017. Conversely, the proportion of women who have never married consistently declined since 1987 but saw a 1.6% point increase in 2017. The percentage of divorced women initially decreased from 1987 to 2002, then rose until 2017. Similarly, the percentage of widowed women declined between 1987 and 2002, followed by fluctuations that showed an overall downward trend. In contrast, the percentage of separated women remained minimal and stable between 2012 and 2017, with no available data for earlier years.

Despite societal disapproval, a small fraction (0.4%) declared cohabitation, with this proportion remaining constant from 2012 to 2017, although it may be underestimated. Before 2012, cohabitation data may have been subsumed under marriage. However, this data predates the 2019 criminal law in Indonesia, which criminalises cohabitation if reported by immediate family members. Therefore, post-2019 data might indicate an even lower percentage of cohabitation due to the possible increased reluctance of individuals to disclose such arrangements.

In Indonesia, many couples envision an ideal marriage where the male possesses a higher socioeconomic status than the female. Furthermore, individuals who remain single into their late 20s may encounter societal pressure to marry. Despite diverse cultural interpretations, the societal perception of marriage in Indonesia aligns closely with traditional conventions, emphasising that sexual activities are exclusively confined to the marital bond. At the same time, since 2000, Indonesia has witnessed a growing trend of delayed marriage and individuals embracing lifelong singleness (Himawan & Suriyah, 2022). Yet, this trend of lifelong singleness often provokes negative reactions from both the government and certain segments of society, who perceive marriage and family formation as fundamental pillars of a robust societal structure (Jones & Yeung, 2014).

Table 1 Percentage change in marital status among women aged 15–49: Indonesia 1987–2017

Year	Never Married	Married	Divorced	Widowed	Cohabitation	Separated	Total
1987	26.4	67.6	3.0	3.1	N/A	N/A	100.0
1991	25.9	68.2	3.1	2.8	N/A	N/A	100.0
1997	25.3	69.7	2.5	2.5	N/A	N/A	100.0
2002	25.0	70.9	2.2	1.9	N/A	N/A	100.0
2007	23.4	72.0	2.4	2.2	N/A	N/A	100.0
2012	21.7	73.0	2.7	2.1	0.4	0.2	100.0
2017	23.3	71.5	2.8	1.8	0.4	0.2	100.0

Source: compiled from Indonesia Demographic and Health Surveys

Despite the declining prevalence of early and arranged marriages during the latter half of the 20th century in Indonesia, the institution of marriage still holds significant social importance. Marriage has long been regarded as an important transition to adulthood (Dommaraju & Tan, 2024). However, it is essential to recognise that marriage alone does not universally signify adulthood. This is particularly relevant for the many young women in Indonesia who married during their teenage years, as highlighted by Grijns et al. (2020).

This historical context is further illuminated by Jones (2023), who showed that in the 1950s and 1960s, Indonesia experienced a significantly higher divorce rate compared to Western countries, attributable to various factors. While divorce was not socially favoured, women were not compelled to remain in incompatible marriages. Society exhibited a general tolerance toward divorce, lacking strong economic deterrents, flexible support arrangements for divorced women and children, and the ease of remarriage.

By the end of the 20th century, however, Indonesia witnessed a significant decline in divorce rates, primarily due to the postponement of marriages to more mature ages and a potentially enhanced scrutiny of prospective partners. Parker (2016) argued that the perceived tolerance toward divorce seen in the 1950s and 1960s shifted during the New Order era (1966–98), resulting in a notable decline in divorce rates and an increase in social stigma surrounding it. The New Order government's patriarchal gender norms and emphasis on nuclear family structures, combined with its policies on marriage and divorce, drove societal changes, including the heightened stigmatisation of divorce, particularly for women.

Yet, what is particularly noteworthy is the shifting societal perspective: where divorce was once a taboo subject, it is now increasingly accepted. This acceptance is reflected in the fact that divorce no longer acts as a substantial deterrent to family life choices, underscoring a broader cultural transformation in attitudes toward marital dissolution. Nevertheless, the apparent rise in divorce rates remains a significant concern for Indonesian society at both national and regional levels (Latifah & Ritonga, 2022).

Furthermore, the connections between divorce, separation, and remarriage are intricate. Individuals who have undergone divorce or separation represent the pool of potential remarriage candidates. Societal patterns, norms, and attitudes toward remarriage wield significant influence over divorce rates. Historically, a key factor contributing to high divorce rates in Islamic Southeast Asia was the widespread acceptance and ease of remarriage. Conversely, in countries such as India, where remarriage is more challenging, divorce rates have remained comparatively low (Dommaraju & Rajasingam, 2023).

Research on remarriage in Indonesia remains limited. The most comprehensive recent study by Mahdi et al. (2023) examined tsunami survivors in Banda Aceh a decade after the December 2004 disaster. The study found that 66% of affected widows and widowers remarried, primarily within the first three years post-disaster. Widows were often motivated by the need for financial stability, support for their children, and societal perceptions of their unmarried status. Widowers, on the other hand, frequently sought domestic assistance and childcare. Some individuals chose

not to remarry due to concerns about financial burdens, potential distress to their children, or, in the case of women, the loss of personal freedoms.

3 Data and methods

This paper calculates marital status transition probabilities using Wave-4 (2007) and Wave-5 (2014) of the Indonesia Family Life Survey (IFLS). The sample is limited only to individuals interviewed in both waves and with available marital status information, enabling the assessment of marital status transition probabilities. The sample excludes those who were interviewed only in either 2007 or 2014. The calculation of the probabilities is based on two points in time, 2007 and 2014, involving respondents aged 15 years and above in 2014.

Several respondents were excluded to ensure data consistency: two observations were removed due to missing birth years in 2014; 332 were excluded due to discrepancies of more than two years in reported birth years between 2007 and 2014; and four were excluded due to discrepancies in reported sex between the two waves. Ultimately, the analysis consists of 23,904 observations. Table 2 presents summary statistics of the analytical sample according to selected variables for both years.

Figure 1 describes the sequence of four marital statuses: never married, married (including cohabited), divorced (including separated), and widowed. The “married” category encompasses both “first married” and “remarried”, while deceased individuals are excluded, as the data only includes those who were alive at the time of the survey. Cohabiting individuals are classified under “married” due to the low percentage of cohabitation, which was just 0.4% nationally in both the 2012 and 2017 Indonesia Demographic and Health Surveys. Similarly, separated individuals are grouped into the “divorced” category, as separations accounted for only 0.2% nationally in the same surveys.

Table 3 serves as the basis for calculating the probabilities of individuals transitioning between marital statuses during this period, as shown in Tables 4, 5, 6 and 7. Each cell in Table 3, denoted as a_{ij} , represents the percentage change from one marital status in 2007 to either a different or the same marital status in 2014. The sum of the percentages in each row equals 1. As discussed below, Table 3 does not necessarily represent the matrix of marital status transition probability. The calculated probabilities are shown in Tables 4, 5, 6 and 7.

Based on Table 3, the probability of remaining never married is calculated directly, as indicated by a_{11} . In contrast, the transition probability from never married to married is derived by summing two probabilities. The first represents never-married individuals in 2007 who transitioned to marriage by 2014 and remained married, shown in a_{12} . The second includes those who transitioned to marriage but were widowed or divorced by 2014, represented by $(a_{13} + a_{14})$. Alternatively, the probability of transitioning from never married to married can be calculated as $(100\% - a_{11})$, where a_{11} denotes the probability of remaining never married in 2014. Notably, the second probability is very small, with only 0.3% transitioning to widowed and 2.4% to divorced. While this paper does not explore these small probabilities in detail, they warrant further investigation in future research.

Table 2 Summary statistics of marital status, demographics, and socioeconomic variables in 2007 and 2014

	2007		2014	
	%	#	%	#
Marital Status		23,904		23,904
Never Married	20.75	4,961	9.30	2,224
Married	71.93	17,195	79.20	18,931
Widowed	5.06	1,209	8.31	1,987
Divorced	2.25	539	3.19	762
Sex				
Male	46.60	11,139	46.60	11,139
Female	53.40	12,765	53.40	12,765
Age				
15–24	23.47	5,611	6.62	1,582
25–34	28.41	6,792	26.70	6,383
35–49	29.20	6,979	36.14	8,638
50 +	18.92	4,522	30.54	7,301
Education¹				
Low	38.35	8,388	37.75	8,108
Middle	50.61	11,071	48.06	10,321
High	11.04	2,416	14.19	3,047
Urban-Rural				
Urban	52.21	12,480	59.93	14,325
Rural	47.79	11,424	40.07	9,579
Islands				
Java	56.91	13,578	56.76	13,542
Sumatra	21.60	5,154	21.63	5,162
Other Islands	21.48	5,125	21.61	5,156
Ethnic Groups				
Javanese	42.36	9,925	41.34	9,472
Sundanese	11.95	2,801	11.57	2,652
Other Ethnic Groups	45.69	10,706	47.09	10,789
Religion				
Islam	89.67	21,000	89.85	19,157
Non-Islam	10.33	2,419	10.15	2,163

¹Low refers to primary education or lower; high refers to university education; and middle is in between

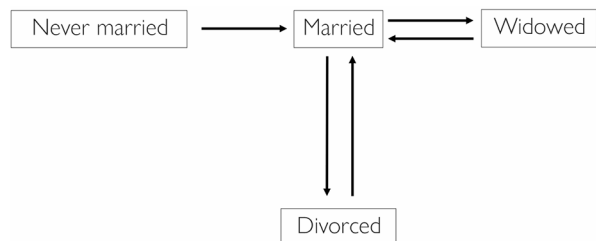
Fig. 1 Sequence of marital status transition

Table 3 Matrix for calculating marital status transition probabilities

		2014			
		Never Married	Married	Widowed	Divorced
2007	Never Married	a11	a12	a13	a14
	Married	0	a22	a23	a24
	Widowed	0	a32	a33	a34
	Divorced	0	a42	a43	a44

Table 4 Transition probabilities: never married to married (2007–2014)¹

Variable	Male + Female	Male	Female
Overall	55.17	48.16	64.90
Age groups			
15–24	38.78	23.21	55.23
25–34	66.92	59.21	79.58
35–49	47.64	49.72	44.29
>=50	14.14	24.00	10.81
Education			
Low Education	58.56	53.52	66.14
Middle Education	60.07	49.82	76.79
High Education	47.38	45.36	49.24
Urban-Rural			
Urban	51.79	44.91	61.32
Rural	62.09	54.79	72.25
Islands			
Java	54.57	46.78	65.71
Sumatra	57.03	49.35	69.18
Others	54.83	50.76	59.46
Ethnicity			
Javanese	58.21	49.67	70.35
Sundanese	63.96	55.97	76.47
Others	53.03	47.22	60.54
Religion			
Islam	58.63	50.79	68.80
Others	47.24	44.26	51.72

¹The probabilities are expressed in percentage

The probability of remaining married is directly shown in a22. The transition probability from married to widowed is denoted as a23, while the transition probability to divorced is represented by a24.

For widowed individuals, the transition probability to remarried is also the sum of two probabilities. The first, a32, represents those widowed in 2007 who remarried between 2007 and 2014 and remained married in 2014. The second, a34, refers to individuals who were widowed in 2007, remarried during this period, but were divorced by 2014. This transition probability can also be calculated as $(100\% - a33)$, where a33 represents the probability of remaining widowed in 2014. Although the second probability is low (2.5%), it warrants further exploration in future research.

Table 5 Transition probabilities: married to widowed or divorced (2007–2014)¹

Variable	Male + Female				Male				Female			
	Married	Widowed	Divorced		Married	Divorced			Married	Widowed	Divorced	
Overall	93.63	4.58	1.79		96.05	1.52			91.53	6.44	2.03	
Age Groups												
15–24	96.51	-	3.49		100.00*	-			96.43	-	3.57	
25–34	96.87	0.40	2.74		96.96	0.46			96.82	0.37	2.80	
35–49	96.34	1.69	1.97		97.58	0.59			95.18	2.72	2.10	
>=50	88.02	11.02	0.96		93.90	5.33			81.20	17.62	1.18	
Education												
Low Education	92.17	6.18	1.65		95.19	3.29			89.64	8.59	1.77	
Middle Education	95.64	2.40	1.97		96.89	1.45			94.54	3.23	2.24	
High Education	96.06	2.14	1.80		97.10	1.67			94.94	2.65	2.41	
Urban-Rural												
Urban	93.45	4.62	1.93		95.93	2.35			91.29	6.59	2.12	
Rural	93.87	4.54	1.60		96.22	2.55			91.85	6.24	1.91	
Islands												
Java	93.48	4.70	1.82		95.69	2.61			91.56	6.52	1.93	
Sumatra	94.23	4.34	1.43		96.45	2.62			92.32	5.82	1.86	
Others	93.46	4.50	2.04		96.58	1.77			90.78	6.84	2.38	
Ethnicity												
Javanese	94.43	3.96	1.61		96.36	2.20			92.86	5.39	1.75	
Sundanese	93.70	4.03	2.27		95.60	1.85			92.24	5.71	2.05	
Others	92.87	5.36	1.77		95.88	2.81			90.13	7.69	2.17	
Religion												
Islam	94.15	4.09	1.76		96.44	2.06			92.29	5.74	1.97	
Others	94.30	4.19	1.51		97.06	1.96			91.87	6.16	1.97	

Notes: ¹The probabilities are expressed in percentage

- There is no sample for the corresponding cell

* Calculated from a small sample (less than 10 respondents)

The transition probability from divorced to remarried is also the sum of two probabilities. The first, a_{42} , refers to those who were divorced in 2007, remarried between 2007 and 2014, and remained married in 2014. The second, a_{43} , refers to those who were divorced in 2007, remarried during the same period, but were widowed by 2014. This transition probability can also be calculated as $(100\% - a_{44})$, where a_{44} indicates the probability of remaining divorced in 2014. Notably, the second probability is significant at 11.9%, and even higher among females at 14.3%, warranting further discussion in future research.

This paper begins by calculating overall probabilities based on age and sex, followed by probabilities disaggregated by education and sex. It then examines probabilities across geographic variables (urban-rural and island) and sex, as well as social markers (ethnicity and religion) and sex. Age is categorized into four groups: young (15–24), adult-1 (25–34), adult-2 (35–49), and older (50 and above). Educational attainment is grouped into three levels: low-level (up to elementary education), medium-level (junior and senior high school), and high-level (university education). Geographic variables include urban-rural residence and residence by islands, categorized into Java Island, Sumatra Island, and Other Islands. Social markers include three ethnic groups (Javanese, Sundanese, and Others) and two religious groups (Muslims and non-Muslims). All variables refer to 2014.

4 Findings

4.1 Starting the journey: from never married to married

4.1.1 Age

This paper finds that the path to marriage remains a significant milestone for many individuals in Indonesia. The transition probability of 55.2% for those who were never married (as shown in Table 4) underscores the importance of marriage as a key transition into adulthood within Indonesian society (Dommaraju & Tan, 2024).

In Table 4, the transition probability from never married to married reveals notable sex differences, with females showing a higher probability of transitioning to marriage (64.9%) compared to males (48.2%). A similar pattern is observed among all categories of education, geographical variables, and social markers. This sex differential aligns with findings from (Situmorang, 2007), which suggested that societal pressure to marry is greater for females.

This societal pressure is particularly evident among younger age groups, specifically those aged 15–24 and 25–34, where the probability of entering marriage is much higher for females than for males. More than half (55.2%) of young females aged 15–24 are likely to transition into marriage, compared to just 23.2% of their male counterparts. The probability peaks in the 25–34 age group, with 79.6% of females and 59.2% of males entering marriage. However, these sex differences reverse in older age groups (35–49 and 50+), where males exhibit a higher likelihood of marrying than females (49.7% versus 44.3% and 24.0% versus 10.8%, respectively).

Table 6 Transition probabilities: widowed to remarriage (2007–2014)¹

Variable	Male + Female	Male	Female
Overall	7.20	16.31	5.99
Age Groups			
15–24	-	-	-
25–34	80.00	-	100.00*
35–49	27.08	23.53	27.85
≥50	5.14	15.45	3.86
Education			
Low Education	6.77	14.86	5.58
Middle Education	10.11	11.11	9.93
High Education	12.12	14.29*	11.54
Urban-Rural			
Urban	7.22	15.94	6.23
Rural	7.17	16.67	5.68
Islands			
Java	7.54	17.05	6.24
Sumatra	6.56	22.22	4.61
Others	6.01	4.00	6.25
Ethnicity			
Javanese	6.20	17.02	4.71
Sundanese	11.86	22.22*	11.01
Others	6.96	13.75	6.02
Religion			
Islam	8.72	20.48	7.27
Others	5.94	20.00	3.49

Notes: ¹The probabilities are expressed in percentage

- There is no sample for the corresponding cell

* Calculated from a small sample (less than 10 respondents)

The lowest transition probability from never married to married is observed among individuals aged 50 and above.

The results in Table 4, particularly for the 15–24 age group, may indicate some instances of child marriage, as some individuals recorded as married in 2014 may have married before turning 18. This aligns with Grijns et al. (2020), who observed that many young Indonesian women marry during their teenage years. Such marriages may not necessarily signify a transition to adulthood. Conversely, societal expectations often pressure women in their late 20s to marry, despite a growing trend toward delayed marriage and lifelong singleness (Himawan & Suriyah, 2022). Further studies are needed to explore these two possible phenomena.

For older females, the transition probability decreases sharply, suggesting reduced opportunities or incentives for marriage as they age, especially after reaching post-reproductive ages (50 years and above). The pattern among older females may indicate a trend of a rising percentage of females who will never be married in their lives.

These findings support Dommaraju's (2023) observations in Southeast Asia, including Indonesia. However, lifelong singleness often provokes negative reactions from both the government and certain segments of society, who view marriage and

Table 7 Transition probabilities: divorced to remarriage (2007–2014)¹

Variable	Male + Female	Male	Female
Overall	42.67	46.38	41.40
Age Groups			
15–24	66.67*	-	66.67*
25–34	73.97	68.75	75.44
35–49	46.57	52.17	43.70
>=50	30.50	30.08	30.10
Education			
Low Education	38.75	43.64	37.30
Middle Education	53.85	48.33	56.88
High Education	46.43	71.43*	38.10
Urban-Rural			
Urban	41.46	42.86	40.98
Rural	44.55	51.85	42.04
Island			
Java	44.59	45.24	44.35
Sumatra	40.51	46.15	37.74
Others	39.73	50.00	37.29
Ethnicity			
Javanese	43.85	41.82	44.70
Sundanese	52.17	50.00	53.06
Others	38.28	50.00	35.00
Religion			
Islam	43.28	46.02	42.33
Others	40.74	55.56*	33.33

Notes: ¹The probabilities are expressed in percentage

- There is no sample for the corresponding cell

* Calculated from a small sample (less than 10 respondents)

family formation as essential pillars of a strong societal structure (Jones & Yeung, 2014).

4.1.2 Education

Education is importantly associated with the transition probability from never married to married. Overall, it takes an inverted U-curve, indicating individuals with middle-level education exhibit the highest probability of transitioning to marriage, while those with low-level education have a lower probability. Conversely, individuals with high-level education experience the lowest likelihood of transitioning to marriage.

Table 4 illustrates a distinct pattern in how education influences the transition from never married to married, with differences between sexes. For females, the inverted U-curve relationship also emerges, where moderate levels of education are associated with a higher likelihood of marriage, but this likelihood decreases at higher levels of education. This suggests that middle-level education may enhance marital prospects for women, while advanced education might correspond to a lower probability of transitioning to marriage.

In contrast, for males, the relationship between education and transition from never married to marriage is consistently negative. Higher educational attainment is linked to a reduced likelihood of transitioning from never married to married. This could indicate that more educated men may prioritize career development or personal independence over marriage.

4.1.3 Geography

Geographical variables play an important role in influencing marriage transitions in Indonesia due to varying cultural, economic, and social conditions. Table 4 indicates that the probability of transitioning from never married to married is notably higher in rural areas (62.1%) compared to urban areas (51.8%), a pattern observed across both sexes. Rural communities often hold more traditional views on marriage and family life, where marriage occurs at younger ages and is more common. Situmorang (2007) highlighted that urban environments, especially in large cities, provide more supportive conditions for never-married females.

By island, Sumatra Island exhibits the highest probability of transitioning from never married to married (57.0%) followed by Other Islands (54.8%) and Java Island, which shows a similar probability (54.6%). However, this pattern varies by sex. Among males, Other Islands and Sumatra Island have the highest, almost identical, probabilities (50.8% and 49.4%, respectively), followed by Java Island. On the other hand, among females, Sumatra Island stands out as having the highest probability to married, followed by Java Island and then Other Islands. Further studies need to explore this pattern.

4.1.4 Social markers

The transition probability from never married to married is also related to ethnicity, functioning as a social marker. Sundanese individuals, Indonesia's second-largest ethnic group, show the highest probability (64.0%), followed by Javanese, the largest group (58.2%), and other ethnic groups (53.0%). This pattern is consistent among both males and females, suggesting a strong cultural influence on marriage patterns within these ethnicities.

Religion, as another social marker, plays a key role, with Muslims showing a higher probability of transitioning from never married to married (58.6%) compared to non-Muslims (47.2%). This pattern holds across sexes, with a larger sex differential among Muslims: 68.8% for females versus 50.8% for males. These variations suggest that religious and cultural contexts importantly shape transitions into marriage.

4.2 Navigating marriage: stability and change

4.2.1 Age

This section explores the trajectories individuals may follow once they marry, focusing on the probabilities of remaining married, transitioning to widowhood, or experiencing divorce. Table 5 indicates that once married, a large majority (93.6%) of

individuals remain married. Marital stability remains high across the reproductive age groups (15–49), with approximately 96.0% of individuals staying married, primarily due to low mortality and divorce rates. However, this drops to 88.0% for those aged 50 and above, likely due to higher mortality rates leading to widowhood.

A clear sex differential is observed in the older age group. Among individuals aged 50 and above, 93.9% of males remain married compared to 81.2% of females. Furthermore, in this older group, 17.6% of females transition to widowed status, a rate over three times higher than the 5.3% observed among males. This disparity is largely attributable to females' longer life expectancy and the common age gap in marriages, where men often marry younger women. As a result, husbands are more likely to pass away first, leaving their wives widowed in older age.

Overall, the transition probability from married to widowed is higher than the transition to divorced. However, a clear sex differential is evident: only 2.4% of males transition to widowed, compared to a significantly higher 6.4% of females. This pattern is primarily attributed to women's longer life expectancy and the typical age gap between spouses.

This pattern—where transitions to widowed surpass transitions to divorced—is most prominent in the older age group. Among adults aged 25–34 and 45–49, marriages are more likely to end in divorce than in widowhood, although the probabilities remain low overall. While probability to divorce is low for both sexes, females are more likely to experience marital dissolution than males.

The lower transition probability from married to divorced compared to widowed may reflect the lower social acceptance of divorce during the 2007–2014 period, to which the transition probabilities refer. Jones (2023) noted that divorce was relatively easy and socially accepted in the 1950s and 1960s. However, Parker (2016) noted that by the end of the 20th century, societal attitudes had shifted, leading to a decline in social acceptance and increased stigmatization of divorced individuals, particularly women. In contrast, Latifah and Ritonga (2022) argued that divorce has become more socially accepted in the 21st century. More recent data may reveal whether this cultural shift has led to higher transition probabilities from married to divorced.

4.2.2 Education

The likelihood of remaining married varies by education levels. Individuals with high-level education exhibit the greatest marital stability, with a 96.1% probability of staying married. This probability is approximately similar to that among individuals with middle-level education (95.6%). It is the lowest among those with low-level education (92.2%). This pattern of marital stability is observed in both sexes.

Education also influences the transition probabilities from married to widowed. Individuals with low-level education face the highest likelihood of becoming widowed, with a transition probability of 6.2%, while those with high-level education have a markedly lower probability of 2.1%. In contrast, educational differences do not play a significant role in the transition from married to divorced, where probabilities range narrowly from 1.7% for those with low-level education to 2.0% for those with middle-level education.

Sex differences are particularly evident in the transition to widowhood, with a more pronounced disparity in educational attainment among females compared to males. For females with low-level education, the probability of transitioning to widowhood is 8.6%, more than three times higher than the 2.7% observed among highly educated females. Among males, this educational disparity is smaller. The probability of transitioning to widowhood for males with low-level education is 3.3%, which is slightly less than three times the 1.5% probability observed among males with middle-level education.

Across all education levels, the probability of transitioning from married to widowed is consistently higher than the probability of transitioning to divorced. This difference is most pronounced among individuals with low-level education, where 6.2% transitioned to widowed compared to only 1.7% who transitioned to divorced. Among females with low-level education, the gap is even wider, with 8.6% becoming widowed compared to just 1.8% who divorced. An exception to this pattern is observed among married males with middle-level education, where the probability of becoming divorced (1.7%) slightly surpasses the probability of becoming widowed (1.5%).

4.2.3 Geography

The likelihood of staying married is nearly identical in both urban (93.5%) and rural (93.9%) areas, regardless of sex. However, marital transitions to widowed or divorced show notable sex differences. Among urban females, the transition probability to widowed is 6.6%, compared to 2.1% for divorced, while in rural areas, these rates are slightly lower at 6.3% and 1.9%, respectively. For males, the gaps are smaller and the probabilities lower, with urban males facing a 2.4% probability of being widowed and 1.7% of divorced, compared to 2.6% and 1.2%, respectively, in rural areas.

The probability of remaining married is almost identical across Indonesia's islands, with 94.2% in Sumatra Island, followed by 93.5% in Java Island and Other Islands. Across all islands and sexes, the transition probability from married to widowed is consistently higher than the transition to divorced, reflecting the overall trend. Sex differences are consistent across island groups, with females more likely than males to transition from marriage to either widowed or divorced.

Among females, the highest transition probability to widowhood is observed in the Other Islands, followed by Java Island and then Sumatra Island. In contrast, for males, the highest transition probability to widowhood is observed in Sumatra Island and Java Island, followed by Other Islands.

A similar geographic pattern is observed for the transition probability to divorce among females. However, the pattern for males is slightly different, with the highest transition probability to divorce observed on Java Island and Other Islands, followed by Sumatra Island.

4.2.4 Social markers

As with the overall pattern, the transition probability from married to widowed is consistently higher than that from married to divorced, regardless of sex and ethnicity. Among ethnic groups, Javanese and Sundanese exhibit the lowest transition probability from married to widowed (4.0%), followed by Other ethnic groups (5.4%). However, this pattern varies by sex. “Other ethnic groups” maintain the highest probability of transitioning to widowhood across both sexes. Among males, Javanese have a higher probability of widowhood than Sundanese, while among females, the Sundanese have a higher probability than Javanese.

The highest transition probability to divorce is observed among Sundanese (2.3%), with notable sex differences. Among males, Sundanese have the highest probability of divorce (2.6%), while among females, the highest probability is seen in Other ethnic groups (2.2%).

In terms of religion, the transition probability from married to widowed is nearly identical between Muslims (4.1%) and non-Muslims (4.2%). However, among females, the probability of transitioning from married to widowed is slightly lower for Muslims (5.7%) compared to non-Muslims (6.2%).

The transition probability to divorce is higher among Muslims (1.8%) compared to non-Muslims (1.5%). This discrepancy may be attributed to the relative difficulty non-Muslims face in obtaining a divorce. Divorce can be relatively difficult for Protestants, as it often involves various doctrinal and legal considerations. In Catholicism, divorce is not recognised, and annulment is the sole option to end a marriage. Among Hindus, the divorce process tends to be complex due to cultural and legal factors. Conversely, the legal process for divorce among Muslims is generally more straightforward. Interestingly, these religious differences are observed only among males; among females, no significant difference in divorce probabilities is noted between Muslims and non-Muslims. Further research is needed to understand this finding.

4.3 Life after marriage: widowhood and remarriage

4.3.1 Age

This section discusses the results of the transitions that occur after the death of a spouse, particularly focusing on the likelihood of remarriage among widowed individuals. The results in Table 6 show that only 7.2% of individuals who were previously widowed transitioned to remarriage. This relatively low percentage reflects the emotional, social, and practical challenges that widowed individuals face when considering remarriage. The transition shows a stark sex difference, with only 6.0% of widowed females remarrying, compared to a much higher 16.3% of widowed males. This may indicate that widowed women face more barriers to remarriage, such as caregiving responsibilities, financial independence, or social stigma. In contrast, widowed men are more likely to remarry, possibly due to different social pressures or the perceived need for companionship and support.

In a study on Aceh, Indonesia, following the deadly 2004 tsunami, Mahdi et al. (2023) showed that approximately two-thirds of widowed individuals remarried

within a decade. Furthermore, most of the remarriages occurred within the first three years after the disaster. The study also highlighted different motivations for remarriage based on gender. Widowed women often remarried to achieve economic security, support their surviving children, and maintain societal reputation. Conversely, widowed men were more motivated to ensure household assistance, personal care, and support in raising their children. Yet, some widowed individuals, both male and female, chose not to remarry because they were concerned with shouldering more financial burdens, potential distress for their children, or, in the case of women, the loss of personal autonomy.

The probability of remarrying after widowhood shows a declining trend across age groups. Adults aged 35–49 have a notably higher remarriage probability at 27.1%, compared to just 5.1% for those aged 50 and above. Caution is warranted when interpreting probabilities for individuals below 35 years of age due to the small sample size.

Sex differences are evident: for males, the probability of remarrying after widowhood decreases with age, from 23.5% for those aged 35–49 to 15.5% for individuals aged 50 and above. In contrast, females exhibit a similar declining trend, but the decline in probabilities is much larger, from 27.9% for ages 35–49 to 3.9% for those in the older age group.

4.3.2 Education

Education plays a crucial role in remarriage probabilities among widowed individuals, with higher education levels generally associated with greater likelihoods of remarriage. Those with low-level education show a remarriage probability of 6.8%, while those with high-level education see this probability rise to 12.1%.

For females, the relationship between education and remarriage is straightforward: higher education levels correlate with higher probabilities of remarriage. Among widowed females with low-level education, only 5.6% remarry, while this figure rises to 9.9% for those with middle-level education and reaches 11.5% for those with high-level education.

The narrative for males, however, is more complex and may follow a U-shaped curve. Males with low-level education have the highest remarriage probability of 14.9%, but this probability declines to 11.1% for those with middle-level education. Estimates for males with high-level education require caution due to the small sample size (fewer than 10 individuals).

4.3.3 Geography

Urban and rural settings are also related to remarriage probabilities among widowed individuals. In urban areas, the probability of remarriage after widowhood is 7.2%, similar to that seen in rural areas. However, a different pattern is seen among the sexes. Among males, the probability of remarrying after widowed is higher in rural areas (16.7%) than in urban areas (15.9%). In contrast, among females, the probability of remarriage is higher in urban areas (6.2%) than in rural areas (5.7%). This result

may suggest that urban environments may offer slightly more opportunities or social acceptance for remarriage among widowed females.

The island landscape of Indonesia adds further variation. Java Island exhibits the highest overall remarriage probability at 7.5%, followed by Sumatra Island at 6.6%, and Other Islands at 6.0%. However, patterns differ by sex. Among males, the highest probability is observed in Sumatra Island (22.2%), followed by Java Island (17.1%) and Other Islands (4.0%). On the other hand, among females, the range of the probabilities is much narrower, varying from 4.6% in Sumatra Island to 6.2% in both Java Island and Other Islands.

4.3.4 Social markers

Ethnicity provides additional context to remarriage probabilities among widowed individuals. Sundanese individuals exhibit the highest probability of remarriage at 11.9%, followed by those categorized as “Others” at 7.0% and Javanese at 6.2%. This pattern is consistent across both sexes, with males generally showing higher remarriage probabilities than females.

Religion also influences remarriage probability, but its effects vary between sexes. Among females, Muslims have a significantly higher probability of remarrying (7.3%) compared to non-Muslims (3.5%). Among males, the probabilities are nearly identical, hovering at approximately 20.0%, regardless of religious affiliation.

4.4 Rebuilding lives: from divorce to remarriage

4.4.1 Age

This section explores the journey individuals undertake after experiencing divorce and their potential path toward remarriage. Divorce, while less common, represents a significant life transition that often brings emotional and social challenges.

Table 7 illustrates that 42.7% of divorced individuals remarry, showcasing a desire to find new partners and establish new relationships. This high probability reflects a societal openness to second chances and the resilience of individuals in rebuilding their lives after marital dissolution. Furthermore, the transition probability from divorced to remarried (42.7%) far exceeds that of transitioning from widowed to remarried (7.2%). Perhaps, divorced individuals may be better prepared and more motivated to remarry than their widowed counterparts.

As discussed by Dommaraju and Rajasingam (2023), higher remarriage probabilities among divorced individuals could stem from societal contexts where remarriage is relatively easy, reflecting a culture that views divorce as a less permanent life event. Consequently, divorced individuals, rather than widowed individuals, form the primary pool for remarriage opportunities.

Table 7 reveals that males have a slightly higher probability of remarrying after divorce (46.4%) compared to females (41.4%). However, this sex difference is much smaller than the disparity observed in the transition from widowed to remarried. Among the older age group (50 and above), the likelihood of remarrying after divorce is nearly the same between the sexes, with around 30.1%. However, among individu-

als aged 25–34, females show a higher remarriage probability of remarrying (75.4%) compared to males (68.8%), a pattern that reverses in the 35–49 age group, where males show a higher probability than females.

Overall, the probability of remarrying after divorce decreases with age for both sexes. Adults aged 25–34 exhibit the highest remarriage probability (74.0%), reflecting their prime reproductive years when marriage is often associated with family formation and having children. This probability declines for older ages (46.6% among ages 35–49 and 30.5% among ages 50 and above). This reflects greater contentment with singlehood or fewer opportunities for remarriage in later life. This age-related pattern remains consistent across both sexes, highlighting a consistent pattern in marital transitions across different age cohorts.

4.4.2 Education

The relationship between educational attainment and the transition probability from divorced to remarried follows an inverted U-curve. Individuals with middle-level education exhibit the highest probability of remarriage (53.9%), while those with low-level education have the lowest probability (38.8%). This pattern holds for females displaying a much higher probability for middle-level education (56.9%). This result does not support the finding by Dommaraju and Rajasingam (2023) in several South and Southeast Asian countries, where females with the lowest levels of education had the highest rate of remarriage.

4.4.3 Geography

The transition probability from divorced to remarried shows a clear urban-rural divide. Individuals in rural areas have a higher likelihood of remarrying after divorce (44.6%) compared to their urban counterparts (41.5%). This pattern is consistent across both sexes, though the gap between the probabilities is higher among males than females.

Geographical differences also extend to Indonesia's islands. Java Island exhibits the highest transition probability for remarriage after divorce at 44.6%, followed by Sumatra Island (40.5%) and Other Islands (39.7%). However, the pattern diverges for males. On Other Islands, males show the highest probability of remarrying after divorce (50.0%), followed by Sumatra Island (46.2%) and Java Island (45.2%). These geographic differences illustrate how local contexts can shape post-divorce remarriage patterns across Indonesia.

Whatever the islands and sexes, the transition probability from divorced to remarried is much higher than the transition probability from widowed to remarried.

4.4.4 Social markers

The relationship between ethnicity and the transition probability from divorced to remarried reveals notable variations. The Sundanese show the highest remarriage probability (52.2%), followed by the Javanese (43.9%) and other ethnicities (38.3%). This pattern, however, shifts when considering males. Among males, the Sundanese

remain the highest (50.0%), but other ethnic groups have the same probability as that of the Sundanese, while the Javanese follow (41.8%).

This paper also concludes that whatever the ethnic groups and sexes, the transition probability from divorced to remarried is much larger than the transition probability from widowed to remarried.

Religion also plays a crucial role in the transition from divorced to remarried. Muslims exhibit a higher overall probability of remarriage after divorce (43.3%) compared to non-Muslims (40.7%). This gap widens significantly among females, where the probability of remarriage for Muslim females is 42.3%, compared to 33.3% for non-Muslim females—a gap of 10% points. However, the gap among males cannot be calculated due to the small number of divorced non-Muslim males (fewer than 10).

Regardless of ethnicity, religion, or sex, the transition probability from divorced to remarried is much larger than the transition probability from widowed to remarried.

5 Concluding remarks: a dynamic landscape

This paper calculates transition probabilities for marital status in Indonesia: from never married to married, from married to widowed or divorced, from widowed to remarried, and from divorced to remarried. It is a quantitative study on changes in marital status, using a probabilistic approach, tracking changes in individuals' marital status over a seven-year period, based on interviews conducted in 2007 and 2014. As the first study of its kind in Indonesia, the calculated statistics will be valuable for socio-economic analyses of marital status transitions in the country. The calculation is conducted across sex, age, education, geography (urban-rural residence and islands), and social markers (ethnicity and religion).

It finds that the transition probability from never married to married is consistently higher among females than males, regardless of education, geography, and social markers. This suggests that pressure to marry may be higher among females than males. The significant movement from never married to married highlights the enduring value placed on marriage. This pattern persists among those aged 15–24 and those aged 25–34. However, the trend shifts in the 35–49 age group, where males have a slightly higher transition probability of marrying. In the older age group, males' probability of marrying far exceeds that of females, reflecting a more limited pool of potential spouses for older females.

Furthermore, once married, most individuals remain married, though some individuals transition to either widowed or divorced status. The transition probability from married to widowed is consistently higher than from married to divorced across all demographic and socio-cultural categories. Notably, exceptions include males with middle-level education and Sundanese males, where the probability of transitioning to widowed is smaller than to divorced.

However, this pattern reflects the one in the older group, where the mortality rate is higher than among the adult group. Among individuals under 50, the probability of transitioning to divorce surpasses the probability of transitioning to widowhood due to lower mortality rates and the potential for remarriage. An exception is observed

among females aged 35–59, where the probability of transitioning to widowed is higher than that of transitioning to divorced.

After becoming widowed or divorced, some individuals remarry. However, the transition probability of transitioning from divorced to remarried is consistently higher than from widowed to remarried, regardless of sex, age, education, geography, and social markers. This finding may indicate that divorced individuals are more likely to pursue remarriage than widowed individuals. In other words, divorced individuals, rather than widowed individuals, are the primary contributors to remarriage.

Additionally, widowed males are notably more likely to remarry than widowed females. However, sex has little impact on the probability of transitioning from divorced to remarried. While males generally have a higher likelihood of remarriage after divorce, the sex difference in this case is minimal for remarriage after divorce. Interestingly, among individuals with middle-level education, as well as within the Javanese and Sundanese ethnic groups, females have a higher probability of remarriage after divorce, contrary to the overall trend.

The calculated probabilities, detailed in Tables 4, 5, 6 and 7, provide valuable insights into the evolving marital landscape in Indonesia, where individuals navigate through different statuses with varying probabilities. As Indonesia continues to evolve, these statistics offer a glimpse into the personal journeys of its people, reflecting both the enduring traditions and the changing norms of contemporary family life.

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Data availability The IFLS wave-5 (2014) and wave-4 (2017) are publicly available. See <https://www.rand.org/well-being/social-and-behavioral-policy/data/FLS/IFLS/ifls5.html> for wave-5 and <https://www.rand.org/well-being/social-and-behavioral-policy/data/FLS/IFLS/ifls4.html> for wave-4.

Declarations

Conflict of interest The authors declare that there is no conflict of interest.

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